

FACTIONS IN POLICY DEBATE: SOME OBSERVATIONS

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When I recently left debate, it was not entirely or even mainly due to the recent fractionalization of the activity. I would admit, however, that the direction of modern debate certainly had dampened my enthusiasm to continue. I could list out the “objective reasons” why I had such a reaction to the growing factions of debate; however, I suppose such an article would only contribute to the problem of two camps that more and more do not speak each other’s language. Instead, I focus on my personal experiences.

With a great amount of joy and anticipation I returned briefly to debate to work for Georgetown University at the 2004 National Debate Tournament, much that was fulfilled. Getting to work for kids that I had coached just the year before, seeing old friends and colleagues, cutting a few “killer” cards and the thrill of the pre-round scramble all made the experience a positive one. Despite that, the end of my visit back into an activity that had occupied the previous 24 years of my life, left me feeling ill at ease about the future of debate. I guess the word I would use to describe my feelings about the state of debate and the future of the activity would be: pessimistic. Here is a list of the experiences that brought on this feeling.

Anger and Hurt

I observed numerous shouting matches. Some were between opponents, some between debaters and judges, some between coaches and judges and others between apparent teammates. I heard some vicious personal attacks during these throw downs. There were accusations about privilege, insensitivity, ignorance, racism, hidden political agendas, and other deeply personal aspects of individual experience. God knows, we have all seen shouting matches at debate tournaments before, but these seemed viscerally different to me than disputes about bad flowing, dropped arguments and standards of judge intervention.

A student left a debate and had to be comforted away from quitting the activity during the tournament. She felt insulted by the debate in which she had just participated. She was offended by people making judgments about her personal experience who did not know her, including the opponents and the judges. She felt uncomfortable and slimy about having to discuss her multi-cultural background as if it were some kind tool to win a debate or a badge of honor to be worn as a passport to credibility. As coaches we've all had to comfort students who felt inadequate at certain points or who were disappointed at having lost a critical debate. This felt a bit different and frankly, it seems to me like personal anger and hurt are the inevitable byproduct of debates increasingly focused on individual identities and experiences. It's one thing to shrug off a judge's or team's rejection of your political disad, it's another to have them reject your family or personal history.

One would expect an increase in personal anger and hurt to result in a corresponding loss of civility in the activity. And I certainly observed this in behavior at the NDT. Even allowing for the separation of personal from political as largely artificial and mythical, I always found that notions that "one attacks an argument not a person" were valuable in teaching students to maintain civility before, during and after debates. Maybe civility was overrated as a commodity, but for whatever reasons I found it to be comforting to me in an otherwise adversarial activity.

Alliances

There have always been alliances in debate; sometimes between like-minded coaches, sometimes between regions and sometimes between friends. The thing that seemed different to me about the alliances I observed at the NDT, were their object and intensity. The object was not just a desire to win debates, rather their goal was literally to undermine the competitive force of a whole set of schools on one side or another. I interpreted the feelings I observed as much more intense than alliances I had seen before. The environment was parsed with phrases like "we at war with THEM," an oddly otherizing behavior for an

academic activity like debate. It reminded me more of realpolitik foreign policy ideologies than of the camaraderie of debate I knew from previous decades of participation.

Loss of Common Language and Standards

I cannot recall, prior to the previous two years of debate, listening to a judge's critique and literally not being able to comprehend a decision making process. That's happened quite a bit in the last two years. Sure, I've witnessed decisions that contained obvious leaps in logic or blinked with the reality I had just seen, but I've always been able to cobble together some sort of coaches "what we did wrong" explanation or a co-judge's "how they saw it differently" understanding of the critique. In this case I am talking about such utterly different ways of viewing the debate that I'm really only guessing at what the explanation of the decision really means. Some of these decisions seem intentionally to be trying not to use logic or what the judge he or she would call "western style reasoning." I suppose it is to be expected that if a judge decides things based on intuition, personal experience, faith or other celebrated "subjective standpoints," it is to be expected that others will have difficulty understanding such language. The whole purpose of such standard cracking decisions is to speak in a new and not yet commonly understood set of symbolic representations. I just wonder where such a loss of common language leads and whether it truly "adds" to our ability to communicate with one another.

Grandstanding and Performance

I think that some of the "grandstanding" at the NDT this past year may have been due to the presence of cameras; the product of the desire of certain persons to look "cool" on camera or spread a particular political viewpoint on debate. I saw a lot of behavior and "acting" and while some of it was probably for the camera, it is clearly the case that performance as an aspect of debate has increased in the last few years. As performances in other activities, I found some of them to be enjoyable, some to be repugnant, some to be funny, and some to be incomprehensible. But in all cases, I found the performances to be

less substantive than traditional modes of debate and interaction. It's hard to take someone seriously when you think they are acting for the camera or the judge. On the whole, I'd rather be spared the performance enhancements and focus on arguments.

Evidence

A conversation from NDT 2004:

Me: So, I've got some good cards on how reading is good and evidence is important.

Other coach: You can't read any cards.

Me: Why? It's just warrants for our arguments.

Other coach: They'll say it oppresses their identity.

Me: How?

Other coach: It doesn't matter. If the debate is about their identity, you are going to lose.

Me: You mean because none of us is in position to question their subjective experiences?

Other coach: Right. That's why you have to play the game not challenge it.

My immediate response to this conversation was incredulity at the utter circularity of it. "You have to be subjective because we subjectivize your 'objective' arguments and there is no way for you to objectively question our subjective experience." The idea that one cannot use pieces of external evidence to inform personal experience seems to me like a completely spurious notion. This summer I engaged a prominent coach who proposes the idea that traditional debate tools like evidence are oppressive. I was informed that his approach was rooted in the ideas Paulo Freire and Bell Hooks. It seemed utterly impossible to me that any educational theorist actually supported the notion of external authors being oppressive, so I read a little and came up with this from Bell Hooks:

I'm so disturbed when my women students behave as though they can only read women, or black students behave as though they can only read blacks, or white students behave as though they can only identify with a white writer. I think the worst thing that can happen to us is to lose sight of the power of empathy and compassion. Absolutely. Then we become brutes. Then we risk being consumed by brutism. There's a statement which I use in all my classes, no matter what I'm teaching. I put on the board the statement, "I am a human being. Nothing human can be alien to me." Then I put it down in Latin, "Homo sum humani nil a me alienum puto." And then I show them its origin. The statement was made by Publius Terentius Afer, known as Terence. He was an African and a slave to a Roman senator. Freed by that senator, he became the most popular playwright in Rome. Six of his plays and that statement have come down to us from 154 bce. This man, not born white, not born free, said I am a human being. I will not have my life narrowed down. I will not bow down to somebody else's whim or to someone else's ignorance. When I finish lecturing, I find that the whole audience, black and white, is a little bit changed, because I will have recited Sonya Sanchez, Anne Marie Evans, and probably Eugene Redmond, and Amiri Baraka, and Shakespeare and Emerson, and maybe talk about Norman Mailer a little bit, because he writes English, and Joan Didion, who writes this language. People see something. I don't know how long the change maintains, but if you have changed at all, you've changed all, at least for a little while. (Hooks, 1998)

Identity

A post NDT conversation:

Me: What do you think is the most important factor in these team's success?

Other coach: They found their own niche and their own voice.

Statements like this bother me a lot. I think it's a great disservice to our activity to think that kids succeed or fail based on preconceived notions of what their identity constitutes. It seems a vast insult to think that a particular student could succeed only by finding his or her own voice. Not only because it denies that student the agency to succeed along a number of possible standards and guidelines, but because it presupposes a single unchanging identity. I think we owe it to our students to teach them that a voice is what you make it. We should tell them that being is chosen not assigned and that what is assigned can be transgressed. To again quote Bell Hooks:

To be changed by ideas was pure pleasure. But to learn ideas that ran counter to values and beliefs learned at home was to place oneself at risk, to enter the danger zone. Home was the place where I was forced to conform to someone else's image of who and what I should be. School was the place where I could forget that self and, through ideas, reinvent myself. (Hooks, 1994, p. 3)

References

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